

Economics 303
Economics of Crime
Fall 2024
Harvill Bldg, Rm 318

Instructor: Randy Hill

Email: randyhill@arizona.edu

Office Hours: By appointment.

Teaching Assistant: Austin Smith,

TA Office Hours: By appointment.

Text: The Economics of Crime: An Introduction to Rational Crime Analysis, 2nd edition, by Harold Winter. Routledge, 2019, ISBN 978-1138607538.

Course Description: An introduction to the study of crime and crime-control policies using standard economic techniques. Students will learn to use the Economist's tools to examine the following: The costs of crime and crime prevention; the behavior of criminals and potential criminals; the markets for crime and criminal behavior and the goods and services that are produced in them; organized crime and key crime issues; and public policies and the need for coordinating criminal justice system.

Course Objectives:

1. Students will learn basic economic analysis of the criminal justice system including both the individual decisions that lead to crime as well as the institutional environment that punishes criminals.
2. Students will learn how to use normative microeconomic analysis to evaluate the efficiency of criminal justice institutions and make policy recommendations.
3. Students will learn how to use positive microeconomic analysis to analyze the effects of policy changes in criminal justice.
4. Students will acquire an understanding of the economic origins of criminal justice institutions and how they evolve.

Expected Learning Outcomes:

1. Students will compare and evaluate the economic arguments supporting various criminal justice policies.
2. Students will be able to identify and evaluate evidence used to create economic arguments.
3. Students will be able to structure written economic analysis of a criminal justice policy.

Grading:

	Points
Homework Assignments	20
Short writing assignments	20
Midterm Exam	30
Final Exam	30
(Optional) Research project	22.5 (See description of project for details)

Homework assignments: There will be four scheduled homework assignments to give students the opportunity to practice skills that will be used in the exams and written assignments. The homework assignments will include solving math problems, finding and summarizing data, and creating data visualizations. Students are free to choose any software packages they like to assist with homework assignments, so long as the submitted work represents their own work, and not the work of someone else, (including AI). Students may work in groups on homework assignments, but each student must submit their own work. Homework assignments will be submitted on D2L by 11:59 PM (midnight) on the due date.

Written assignments: Quality writing is a vital skill in the professional world. The writing assignments will be structured to help students develop the skills required to write effectively on topics of interest to business, government and academic professionals. The assignments are designed to be short requiring students to carefully organize their analysis and arguments.

Students are encouraged to use all available resources to advance their writing skills, including AI and campus writing lab resources. However, such resources are only to be used to IMPROVE upon the student's work, not to generate the written work. Students can receive an additional 2 extra credit points by submitting additional work along with the written assignments. (See Extra Credit). All written assignments will be submitted on D2L by 11:59 PM (midnight) on the due date.

Extra Credit: Students may receive 1 extra credit point (on one written assignment of their choice) by using AI to improve their written assignments. To receive the extra credit point, the students must submit a first draft, a full transcript of the AI interaction, and the final draft of the written assignment. The combined materials should demonstrate that the student used AI to improve the organization, the arguments, the evidence, and/or the style of work presented in the final draft.

Students may receive 1 extra credit point (on one written assignment of their choice) by submitting a draft of the assignment to a campus writing lab to improve their written assignment. To receive the extra credit point, the students must submit a first draft, the recommendations from the writing lab, and a final draft of the written assignment. The combined materials should demonstrate that the student considered the feedback of writing experts to improve the organization, the arguments, the evidence, and/or the style of work presented in the final draft.

Midterm Exam: There will be a single midterm exam covering materials from Section 1 and Section 2 of the course, including Homework and writing assignments (See Tentative Schedule). Any appeals to an exam grade must be submitted in writing within one week from when the graded exam is returned.

Final Exam: The final exam is scheduled on **Thursday 12/19 at 8:00 AM** in **Harvill Bldg, Rm 318**. The final exam will cover materials from Section 3 and Section 4 of the course (See Tentative Schedule).

Make-up Exams: Students are expected to take the exams on the day that they are scheduled. If a student has a University-approved scheduled absence on the scheduled day of an exam, they must arrange with the instructor to take the exam prior to the exam date. For unexpected and unscheduled, University-approved absences on examination days, the exam must be made up within 1 week of the student being able to resume coursework. Students who take a make up exam following these guidelines will NOT be penalized. Students who fail to take the exam on the scheduled date, or who fail to schedule a make-up exam following these guidelines will receive a score of 0 for that exam.

(Optional) Research Project: Students may choose to complete a research project to improve their grade on ONE exam. The research project must focus on economic analysis of a criminal justice topic (but may focus on a topic not covered in class.) The project will be a well-researched policy recommendation. The student must take a position on some change to a local, state, or national criminal justice policy.

The student is expected to identify a policy, explain the history and reasons behind the existing policy, argue why the policy should change, explain clearly how the policy can be improved, and what effects the proposed change to the policy would be expected to have. The student should use all of the tools acquired through this course (and any previous courses) to develop well-structured arguments based on evidence to support the student's preferred policy change. While there is no formal page or word minimum for the assignment, the detail required by the project can probably not be completed in fewer than 10 pages. The research project (if completed) will be due on the final day of classes – Wed 12/11/2024. There will be no opportunity for late submission of the research project.

The grade assigned to the project will replace $\frac{3}{4}$ of the lower of the two exam scores. The remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ of the exam grade will come from the grade assigned to the exam. For example, if a student earned 50% of the available points on the midterm exam, and 90% of the available points on the project, then the student will receive $0.25 \cdot 15 + .75 \cdot 27 = 24$ points as the grade on the midterm exam. The research project grade will NOT be used to penalize a student. If the unadjusted exam grades are better than the grade adjusted by the research project, then the student will be graded on the exams only.

Late Work: Students may turn in homework and written assignments after the due date but will receive a penalty to their grade on the assignment. Work turned in up to 24 hours after the due date will receive a 1 point penalty. Work turned in later than 24 hours after the due date will receive a 2 point penalty. All work (including late assignments) must be submitted by the final day of classes – Wed 12/11/2024. Any work not turned in by midnight 12/11 will receive 0 points.

Final Course Grade Structure: The following table contains the grading scale that will be consistently applied to all students. As indicated by the table, rounding is done to the nearest hundredths. When assigning the final grade, no matter where the line is drawn, there will always be some students that are 0.01 percentage points from a higher course grade.

Course Score (%)	Grade
90-100	A
80-89.99	B
70-79.99	C
60-69.99	D
Below 60	E

Tentative Schedule

Date	Topic
8/27	Introduction to the course
8/29	Introduction to the criminal justice system
8/30	Homework 1 – Weighted averages and expected values
9/3	Rational economic model of crime I
9/5	Rational economic model of crime II
9/10	Policing I
9/12	Courts
9/13	Writing 1 – 5 Paragraph essay structure
9/17	Punishment
9/19	Prisons
9/24	Fines I
9/26	Fines II
9/27	Homework 2 – Data summary
10/1	Death Penalty – End of Section 1
10/3	Behavioral Model I
10/8	Behavioral Model II
10/10	Writing 2 – Hometown Crime
10/11	Race and Poverty
10/15	Recidivism
10/17	Private Deterrence
10/22	Discrimination
10/24	Policing II – End of Section II
10/25	Homework 3 – Data visualization I
10/29	Midterm Exam
10/31	Guns
11/5	Terrorism I
11/7	Terrorism II
11/8	Writing 3 – Causes of Crime
11/12	Drugs
11/14	Civil rights
11/19	Civil asset forfeiture – End of Section 3
11/21	Institutional model
11/22	Homework 4 - Data Visualization II
11/26	Guest Lecture – Video – No class
11/28	Thanksgiving Holiday – No class
12/3	Policing III
12/5	TBD
12/6	Writing 4 – Policy recommendation
12/10	TBD – End of Section 4
12/11	Research Project due - Last day to turn in late assignments
12/19	Final Exam

Academic Integrity: As a student at the University of Arizona you are expected adhere to strict standards of academic integrity. <http://deanofstudents.arizona.edu/academic-integrity/students/academic-integrity>. The expected costs of academic dishonesty are real and high; the incident will be reported to the dean's office and you will definitely get a zero on the assignment and will likely fail the course.

Accessibility and Accommodations: At the University of Arizona, we strive to make learning experiences as accessible as possible. If you anticipate or experience barriers based on disability or pregnancy, please contact the Disability Resource Center (520-621-3268, <https://drc.arizona.edu>) to establish reasonable accommodations.

Class Attendance, Participation and Excused Absences: Students are expected to come to class on time, stay for the duration of the class period, be engaged in the learning process, and participate in a way that enhances the learning experience of their peers. Students that regularly attend class and take class seriously do significantly better than students that do not. Any reasonable absence due to a sincerely held religious belief, observance, or practice will be considered an excused absence (see policy.arizona.edu/human-resources/religious-accommodation-policy). Also, absences that are pre-approved by the UA Dean of Students are considered excused absences.

Technology in the Classroom: No texting, accepting phone calls, or using a laptop (outside of normal classroom activity) is permitted. Disruptive or offensive behavior will not be tolerated. As a courtesy, please notify the instructor prior to deploying any recording equipment or software.

Threatening Behavior Policy: The University seeks to promote a safe environment where students and employees may participate in the educational process without compromising their health, safety, or welfare. The Arizona Board of Regents (ABOR) Student Code of Conduct, ABOR Policy 5-308, prohibits threats of physical harm to any member of the University community, including to one's self. Threatening behavior can harm and disrupt the University, its community, and its families. For more information please see <http://policy.arizona.edu/education-and-student-affairs/threatening-behavior-students>.

Nondiscrimination and Anti-harassment Policy: The University of Arizona is committed to creating and maintaining an environment free of discrimination. In support of this commitment, the University prohibits discrimination, including harassment and retaliation, based on a protected classification, including race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, veteran status, sexual orientation, gender identity, or genetic information. The University encourages anyone who believes he or she has been the subject of discrimination to report the matter immediately as described in the section below, "Reporting Discrimination, Harassment, or Retaliation." All members of the University community are responsible for participating in creating a campus environment free from all forms of prohibited discrimination and for cooperating with University officials who investigate allegations of policy violations. Please see <http://policy.arizona.edu/human-resources/nondiscrimination-and-anti-harassment-policy> for more information.

Tentative Syllabus Policy: Information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade and absence policy, may be subject to change with advance notice, as deemed appropriate by the instructor.